

INSTRUCTIONAL AND COMMUNICATION PRACTICES FOR SENSITIVE AND CONTROVERSIAL STANDARDS

The Virginia Standards of Learning and the LCPS Curriculum include topics that are controversial and/ or sensitive. When approaching controversial or sensitive curriculum standards, it is important to foster a learning environment that develops students' critical-thinking skills, allows for student ownership of learning, and reflects sensitivity to the emotions often engendered by such topics. The purpose of this regulation is to provide instructional staff with classroom practices for mitigating bias and expectations for communication with stakeholders.

A. Instructional Practices for Mitigating Bias

1. Teachers are responsible for creating a welcoming, inclusive, and affirming environment. This environment is a space where people can find themselves represented and reflected, and where they understand that all people are treated with respect and dignity. In a welcoming, inclusive, and affirming environment, deeper learning is more likely to occur. The following actions support the creation of this environment:

- a. Teachers will provide rigorous instruction that includes opportunities for students to make authentic connections to the content.
- b. Teachers will establish classroom norms and routines to support a student's sense of psychological safety.
- c. Teachers should consistently apply strategies to engage families and communicate curriculum objectives and standards.

2. Teachers will consider their own beliefs and values and how it might impact their instructional practices and facilitation of the conversation around controversial and sensitive curriculum standards.

3. Teachers are responsible for delivering instruction that gives students ownership of the learning and an opportunity to develop as critical thinkers.

- a. It is important that teachers adhere to VDOE Standards, LCPS Curriculum, and that instructional strategies align with the LCPS Profile of a Graduate.
- b. Teachers will employ student-driven instructional methods for teaching controversial and sensitive curriculum standards.
- c. Teachers should provide structures for student-driven discussion and collaboration.
 - (i) Teachers will serve as facilitators of conversation and collaboration.

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- (ii) Teachers will intervene if the conversation disrupts learning and/or disrespects personal dignity.
- (iii) Teachers will provide students the opportunity to explore resources that reflect a range of perspectives and experiences.
- (iv) Teachers should gather student feedback and reflect on instructional strategies used in the lesson.

B. Expectations for Communication with Stakeholders

1. Prior to engaging in a planned lesson on sensitive or controversial content, teachers must inform families and students of learning goals.
2. Teachers should be aware that students might have strong reactions to controversial or sensitive content. Families and school counselors should be informed when reactions interrupt student learning.
3. Teachers must consult with their school administrators before inviting guests to speak on controversial or sensitive topics.